who made up the Vaishyas; and from his feet the Sudras, the workers, artisans and servants, were born.

The verse has been challenged, especially by the great constitutionalist and Dalit leader Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar, who considered it a fraudulent attempt to legitimise caste discrimination, but there is little doubt that many Hindus believed that the caste system had religious sanction. Ironically, as I have demonstrated in my 2017 book *Inglorious Empire: What the British Did to India*, India had castes, but not a caste system: the rigidities of caste as we understand it today were introduced by the British in their desire to understand, categorise, and classify the people they were ruling, in order to control them all the better. What the writer on Hinduism Devdutt Pattanaik describes as the attempt by the British to 'force-fit' some 3,000 *jatis* (castes, or some say sub-castes, grouped around hereditary professions) into the four varnas established in the Dharmashastras, has given us a complex 'caste system' whose uneven persistence in Hindu society has been the source of both iniquity and confusion.

The language of the Purusha Sukta verse would seem to rule out any but Brahmin priests in Hindu temples, and yet *shudra archakas* (low caste sacerdotes) perform rituals in many Hindu places of worship, and in October 2017 the Travancore Devaswom (temple board) officially appointed thirty-six non-Brahmin priests, including six Dalits (the former 'Untouchables' who were not even admitted to Kerala's temples till 1936 and who are still denied access to the sanctum sanctorum in many temples where that privilege is reserved only for those who wear the sacred thread, namely Brahmins). It is conventional wisdom that the caste system confined all learning to a narrow privileged caste of Brahmins, yet Veda Vyasa, the compiler of the Vedas, was born to a low-caste fisherwoman, and Valmiki, the author of the *Ramayana*, was a low-caste hunter; both are revered today, even by the Brahmins.

Caste may well have originated in Hinduism's desire to accommodate the different racial, sectarian, and occupational groups it encountered, in a social hierarchy: Dr Radhakrishnan called it 'the answer of Hinduism to the forces pressing on it from outside', an instrument to 'civilise' different tribes it absorbed. To this great scholar, caste 'stands for the